

Not a Local Failure

School closures read as local stories: a shrinking district, an empty building, a hard vote at a board meeting. The pattern underneath is statewide, and it runs through Austin.

135

SCHOOLS CLOSED OR APPROVED TO CLOSE SINCE LATE 2023

22 → 50 → 55

CLOSURES VOTED, 2024 → 2025 → FIRST HALF OF 2026

\$55

PER-PUPIL INCREASE, 2025 – VS. \$1,300+ NEEDED TO MATCH INFLATION SINCE 2019

\$1B

VOUCHER PROGRAM · 85K ACCEPTED, 121K WAITLISTED, FALL 2026

Two doors out, one hallway in

Closures happen through two distinct mechanisms. The first is budget math: state funding follows attendance, enrollment falls, deficits grow, and local boards close campuses to survive. Nobody cites test scores; the spreadsheet does the work. The second is accountability law: if one campus fails state ratings five years running, Texas must close it or take over the entire district. Houston, Fort Worth, and Beaumont are now run by state-appointed boards, and those boards are closing schools in bulk — Fort Worth alone has 19 campuses slated by 2029.

Different doors, same hallway. Both trace to the same funding position: Texas ranks in the bottom ten states for per-pupil spending, and went six years without a comprehensive increase while the governor conditioned any new money on a voucher program passing first.

The exit ramp and who can use it

The state's built alternative is the Education Savings Account: 85,000+ acceptances in year one, 121,000 waitlisted, awards averaging \$7,500–\$8,000. The state's first report (Aug 2026) complicates the story in both directions. By its income tiers the money went mostly to low-income families, with fewer than 30 awards in the wealthiest group — so “handout to the rich” doesn't hold. But recipients are 41% white against a 24% white public-school population, most invited families were already in private or home school, and the report omits how many recipients ever attended public school. The equity gap is access, not income: tuition beyond the award, admissions discretion, and geography. The communities losing their schools are largely the ones that can't complete the exit.

What cuts against this

Honest counterweights: enrollment decline is real and partly demographic — birth rates and charter growth predate vouchers. Consolidation defenders argue that half-empty buildings spread resources thinner per student, so closing campuses can concentrate funding and improve what each remaining student receives. Whether displaced students actually end up better off is an empirical question, and the closure data itself comes from a public-school advocacy nonprofit. The sequence of funding decisions, though, is on the public record.

THE OPEN QUESTION

What does a local failure mean when it happens in every region of the state at once?